



Individual needs: According to the author, every cricketer's body is different, so applying one fitness standard to all is nearly impossible. GETTY IMAGES

gave their hearts and souls in extreme weather conditions, often playing in front of empty stadiums and on pitches that were not the greatest. Being selected for the zonal teams and having their performances noticed not just by the general public but also by the selectors is a significant boost for these hardy cricketers, most of whom don't feature in IPL teams. The BCCI must be lauded for doing this, and the Duleep Trophy should always be a zonal teams' competition as it was envisaged when it first started.

Another decision to introduce a fitness test, called the Bronco Test, is a new feature. While it is fine to have these tests to get a general idea of where a player needs to strengthen their body, having them decide selection to the national team is a tad too much. Every person's body is different, so having one standard for everybody in the squad is well-nigh impossible.

There has to be consideration given to the player's speciality and allowances made for that. For example, a wicketkeeper, who is constantly on the move the whole day, requires a different fitness level than the others. The fast bowlers will be different from the spinners, though the spinners will invariably bowl as many, if not more, overs in the day than them. The batters will need a different kind of fitness. As you can see, there is no such thing as a 'one-size-fits-all' approach. As long as this is taken into account and the strict parameters of the new test are not followed rigidly, then it is fine.

The most important test for playing at the highest level for your country cannot be measured, as it's between the two ears. And the clincher for me is when the heart is opened, it should have only two words, 'Indian cricket', and nothing else.



The decision to have the Duleep Trophy on a zonal basis again is a good one, as it opens the doors to many players who, in earlier seasons, gave their hearts and souls in extreme weather conditions, often playing in front of empty stadiums and on pitches that were not the greatest.